

Part 7: Comrades On The Battlefield

7.1 Character Composition and Squad Creation

So, you've decided to form a crew and take your chances in the Zone. Well then let's talk about leaders and *khraabrost'*.

The Crew Leader is in charge of the squad and that leader represents you; competent, experienced, determined to make your fortune. Select a miniature that best reflects the style and type of soldier you want to be and give it the following Stats and equipment:

Movement Rate of 6", Combat Ability of 6, Military Body Armor (Armor 6), and a Will of 7. Classed as a Veteran, they will have three (3) Actions per turn and two Wounds.

Next, select one Ranged Weapon and one Melee Weapon, two grenades of any type, and three items from the Basic Equipment table (see pages 25 and 32). Finally, assign them the Leader Skill plus one other Skill you feel will give you and your crew an edge in the Zone.

When you're done, your stat sheet should look something like this:

Name	Boris	Faction	Military
Wounds	2	Combat Experience	Veteran
Movement	Combat Ability	Armor	Will
6"/Action	6	Mil-Body Armor (6)	7
Skills			
Leader: Leaders grant a +1 bonus to all Will/Rally rolls for allied units in Line of Sight to the Leader figure. Leaders also have a special 'Order' Action that allows them to 'transfer' their Actions to other members of their squad. The recipient must be within 12" and in Line of Sight of the Leader figure, and must immediately perform the Ordered Action. Any effects of this transferred Action/s must be taken and resolved before the Leader can perform any more Actions. Hustle: Quick on their feet, whenever this model spends two consecutive Actions to Move, they receive an extra 2" to the total. A Hardened trooper can move 14" with two back-to-back Move Actions rather than the standard 12".			
Equipment			
Military Body Armor: Armor 6. Model counts as Obscured Target from Ranged Attacks when in Cover. Slot 1: Electric Juice – Methamphetamine and Vodka. Immediately grants two additional Actions. Side Effect – Only One Action allowed the following turn. Slot 2: Med-Kit – Replace 1 Wound with 2 Pinned Counters. Free Action and is Self-Administered. 1 Action otherwise. Slot 3: Red Dot – (on AK-15) +1 to Ranged Attack Combat Ability Roll at half weapon's effective range or less.			

Weapon	Range	Firepower	Damage
AK-74	1-36"	3	1
MP 443 Grach Pistol	Melee-12"	1	0
RGN Grenades (x 2)	1-18"	1	SBT 2/model

Khrabrost'

They say you can't measure an intangible like courage, only see it in action. Well *Khrabrost'* (translated from Russian as 'mettle, bravery, or courage') is how *Zona Alfa* measures a Zone Crew's potential effectiveness in battle. It's the main value used to build a squad.

A Zone Crew's *Khrabrost'* (K) is equal to the total available Actions among its members. A normal, starting crew's *Khrabrost'* is Twelve. The Leader takes up three of those, so there are nine *Khrabrost'* left to 'spend' to recruit the remaining squad members. Veterans cost three, Hardened men cost two, and Rookies cost one.

Section 8 explains how crew members can improve their capabilities and gain Advances over the course of a campaign, so it's possible a Leader could take a risk of Green rookies and slowly, steadily build them up. A safer bet might be to take several Hardened men, or perhaps another Veteran and a single Rookie. It's your call.

The player does not have to spend the *Khrabrost'* limit on squad members when creating a crew. Leftover *Khrabrost'* points can be used to boost another member's Stats instead. If for example they elect to add only one Hardened and one Rookie member, the leftover points can raise any single member's Movement, Combat Ability or Will by 1 (1" in the case of Movement).

Crew members are still allowed to select their Weapons, Grenades, Skills and Abilities, and Equipment (see pages 25, 30, and 32). However, the newly recruited members start with the following Stats, Skills, and Equipment capacity depending on their Combat Experience. The starting stat lines for each type are below.

12K is the value used for starting crews. It can increase with hires and promotions – and decrease due to casualties – over the course of a campaign. At some point, players may well find themselves forced to adjust their style of play and mission objectives because of uneven odds. 12K is also a starting point for force values for two player pick-up games. You and your opponent may agree to a 16K, 10K, or 8 K game. Whatever fits your collection.

Rookie (1K Each) 1 Action Per Activation

Name	Movement	Combat Ability	Armor	Will
Dmitry Dukh	5"	4	Improvised Body Armor (3) Counts as Obscured Target when in Cover.	4
Options				
Choose 1 Ranged Weapon, 1 Melee Weapon. 2 Grenades, and 1 Piece of Basic Equipment.				

Hardened (2K Each) 2 Actions Per Activation

Name	Movement	Combat Ability	Armor	Will
Kirill Kirza	6"	5	Civilian Body Armor (5) Counts as Obscured Target when in Cover.	5
Options				
Choose 1 Ranged Weapon, 1 Melee Weapon. 2 Grenade, 1 Skill, 2 Pieces of Basic Equipment.				

Veteran (3K Each) 3 Actions Per Activation

Name	Movement	Combat Ability	Armor	Will
Timur Tyazheliy	6"	6	Civilian Body Armor (5) Counts as Obscured Target when in Cover.	6
Options				
Choose 1 Ranged Weapon, 1 Melee Weapon. 2 Grenades, 2 Skills, 3 Pieces of Basic Equipment.				

7.2 Factions

The final thing you got to do before heading out is choose a Faction, because like it or not, you've got to pick a side.

There are six Factions in the Exclusion Zone, and while you have to pay Faction Dues, membership has its benefits. Depending on your choice, you get a couple pieces of special Gear for your Crew as a 'signing bonus', discounts when buying certain items at The Stalls (see Section 8.6, page 51 for details), and find it easier to recruit certain skilled team members later in the game. The specifics depend on which one you join. The Factions and their benefits are explained below.

Military

The Zone Enforcement Unit is tasked with containing the Zone and interdicting the flow of illegal Salvage and dangerous artifacts. Ironical as it's the Military that secretly allows and assists in the flow of said items. Military Crews start with three free pieces of Equipment: two Red Dot Sights and one load of Hot Load Ammo. They get a 20% discount when purchasing new Weapons, and can recruit Rookies at 25% less of the normal price later in the game.

Scientists

Affiliated with the government and several large private research agencies, the Scientist faction studies the Zone, hoping to understand – and control – its causes and effects. Although technically protected by the military's Zone Enforcement Unit, they frequently hire teams to perform elemental research in dangerous areas, run errands, and provide security. Scientist crews start with a free Detector, one free Med-Kit, and one free Tool Kit. They receive a 25% discount when purchasing Med-Kits, Tool Kits, Gas Masks, and Binoculars at The Stalls, and can hire two Hardened recruits at 50% the normal price later in the game.

Bandits

Vultures, jackals, scavengers, vermin, maggots... the epithets are endless. These thugs rob, harass, and extort anyone and everyone they can. Some Bandits crews are street gangs seeking new turf, others are extensions of organized crime syndicates muscling in on the lucrative flow of goods in and out of the Zone. It's all about money. Bandit crews start with two free doses of Electric Juice and a Chest Rig. They always receive one free Molotov Cocktail when visiting the Stalls. Later in the game, they can hire one Veteran recruit at 25% less the normal price and can always recruit at Rookies 50% normal price.

Independents

Everyone's got to make a living and this bunch plies their trade in the Zone. Whether it's scavenging for artifacts, acting as a guide to researchers and thrill-seeking tourists, or hunting mutants for bounty, Independents want to be left alone and get on with their lives. Independents receive a free Gas Mask, Med-Kit, and Scope to start, and get a 20% discount on Basic Equipment items at the Stalls. Independents can always add Hardened recruits at 30% less the going rate.

Cultists

'If you find a kettle of crazy, it's best not to stir it'. Well, the Zone is a whole cauldron of madness and there's no shortage of folks willing to whip it to a boil. Cultists

believe the Zone is a mystical, mysterious place, and have devoted their lives to see it grow and spread. Technically odds with everyone else, Cultists nonetheless have uneasy alliances with Scientists and Traders, passing valuable information and rare artifacts for profit. Cultists receive a free set of NODs and two Med-Kits when starting. They receive a 20% discount on all Advanced Equipment items: the Stalls, and when hiring new Crew members later in the campaign, their first Veteran and Rookie recruits are free.

Traders

Someone has to grease the wheels of commerce and they are the guys who keep it all moving. Traders pass goods and information in and out of the Zone and among the various Factions. This makes them extremely useful, as well as a frequent target of Bandits. Because of this, Traders are always looking for reliable security. Traders do not receive any additional starting Gear. However, they receive a permanent 40% discount on all items at the Stalls and can hire Veteran recruits at a 25% discount.

Faction Dues

To enjoy the benefits of your declared alliance, you must pay Faction Dues after each Zone Run, successful or not. 10% of the total value of all Salvage and artifacts is automatically deducted from the total. If no salvage is taken, the Faction deducts 10% from the crew's current Zone Script reserve, including the amount in the 10,000 Ruble Retirement Fund.

Allies and Enemies

So, you chose a Faction and have friends inside the Zone. Great that someone has your back. Problem is that means you have Enemies now too – someone who will stab you in the back, given half a chance.

Relationships in the Zone come in three flavors: Allied, Neutral, Enemy. In *Zona Alfa*, anytime you encounter members of a different Faction, there are certain obligations, animosities, and unspoken agreements that come into play.

- **Allied** crews have made pledges of mutual assistance. These groups avoid attacking one another and concentrate on common enemies and common interests. Allied crews tend to cooperate on Zone Runs to eliminate any Zone Hostiles and split the Salvage. In order to break an alliance and attack an Allied crew, a Crew Leader must pass a one-time Will check at Difficulty 4 (Will Stat on a D10, subtract 4 from the roll result). This roll does not need to be declared to the other players, however it requires two Actions to make. If successful, the player may then act in whatever manner they deem expedient. If an attack is made, the two particular crews are classed as Enemies for the rest of the campaign.
- **Neutral** doesn't necessarily mean friendly. In a dangerous place like the Zone, "Live and let live" can be the order of the day. However, there are no obligations or understandings one way or another when facing a Neutral Crew, so Leaders can use approach the mission any way they want.
- **Enemy** crews fight like junkyard dogs the moment they spot each other. Anytime an Enemy Crew is in the mission area, Mission Objectives and Salvage become secondary and the destruction or rout of the Enemy is the team's priority. All Objectives and Hot Spots are ignored. If a Crew Leader wants to override this antagonism, they must roll a one-time Will check at Difficulty 2

(Will Stat on a D10, subtract 2 from the roll result). A Success means they can act normally for the rest of the game, otherwise, Mission Objectives and Hot Spots can only be pursued after the enemy Crew is dealt with.

Below is the table of alliances and grudges between the Zone Factions. Read the table rows left to right to determine your default reaction to members of a particular Faction. Notice the attitudes among the Factions aren't necessarily reciprocal; groups have their own motivations for helping others, reasons that might not be mutual.

Faction Alliance Table						
Faction	Military	Scientists	Bandits	Independents	Cultists	Traders
Military	Allied	Allied	Enemy	Neutral	Enemy	Neutral
Scientists	Allied	Allied	Neutral	Allied	Neutral	Allied
Bandits	Enemy	Enemy	Allied	Neutral	Neutral	Enemy
Independents	Neutral	Allied	Neutral	Allied	Neutral	Allied
Cultists	Enemy	Neutral	Neutral	Neutral	Allied	Allied
Traders	Neutral	Allied	Enemy	Neutral	Allied	Allied

There you have it. Once you have created your Leader and Crew, kitted them out as best you can, signed on with a Faction, you're ready to enter the Exclusion Zone.

Ni Pukha, Ni Pyera, comrade!